he welcomed us in the usual manner and said only that he regretted Shuja's present misfortunes, and trusted it would please God to favour him again.'[58]

The news Shah Zaman brought with him could not have been worse. Shuja's defeat had been absolute. His army had been advancing from Jalalabad towards Kabul and its vanguard had just reached the cypresses of the Mughal garden at Nimla when his forces had been ambushed while still strung out along the road. The rebels had ridden them down with their lances and their sharp Khyber knives, screaming and spearing and clubbing with the buttstocks of their muskets. The lanced and punctured bodies fell as if suddenly deflated. Then the riders dismounted to gut and desecrate the torsos of the fallen, and slice off their genitals to place in the corpses' mouths. Within minutes, Shuja's general was dead, and the new recruits had bolted. Many of his noblemen, won over by the bribes offered by Fatteh Khan Barakzai, now changed sides.[59] Shah Shuja had been towards the rear of the procession. By the time he came to hear of the ambush, it was already over. His new army had disintegrated, and in the chaos of the headlong flight he became detached even from his own bodyguard.

Later, in the thunderous twilight, a storm crashed over the broken army, the noise drowning out the dull clop of the exhausted horses. 'The scourge of heaven was such that it rained enough that day to flood the river, and it became almost impossible to cross it,' recorded the *Tarikh-i-Sultani*. 'But Shah Shuja trusting to the Almighty entered the stream with his horse.' At first, the keel of the horse's breastbone cut through the waters, and the stallion kept its footing on the shingled strands of the Kabul River. But Shuja 'had forded only till midway when a torrent came, and he slipped from his mount. Eventually he and the horse, with much difficulty, swam across to the other side; but the rest of the soldiers refused to make the crossing. So it was that the Shah ended up spending the night alone, deserted by every one of his courtiers and servants.'[60] Shuja himself put it more succinctly. 'We were left alone and unprotected,' he wrote, 'like a precious stone in its setting.'[61]

The king whose year had begun so auspiciously, and who had put on such a dazzling and theatrical display of absolute power only a few weeks earlier, was once again, as in his youth, a lone fugitive, cantering blindly through the darker provinces of the Afghan night.